structures would have looked the same because the walls of its buildings had across the centuries been evenly and thickly coated with a mixture of mud plaster and straw.[18]

Beyond that remarkable homogeneity given by mud plaster, the character of the house walls and public buildings had changed. These were now of stone, made from locally available varieties of a hard limestone found in the neighbouring foothills and the very soft lime kanjur available all over the plains.[19] Whereas the constructions of earlier settlements at Taxila were generally of a rough and loose rubble masonry, the blocks of buildings that made up the Mauryan city were neat and compact. The archaeological strata here span several centuries, going back to the fifth century BCE, if not earlier (this being designated strata IV), and continuing till the invasion of the Bactrian Greeks in the second century BCE (represented by the first or uppermost stratum). The Mauryan was the second stratum, and the walls of buildings of this period showed more careful and clean ways of construction. The stone walls, though, would not have been visible to the royal visitor because the practice of cladding them externally and internally with plaster seems to have persisted despite the improved building materials. The city's appearance will have struck Ashoka as starkly different from that of most of the cities seen on the way to Taxila: cities like Kaushambi and Hastinapur were brick-built since they stood on alluvial expanses bereft of stone.

Usually, the impression given by a city depends upon the harmony between the geometry of its streets and lanes with the residential and public structures that border them. Entering Taxila, the main street will have impressed the party from Pataliputra. Because of its width, averaging some 7 metres and its more or less straight alignment, 'First Street' is what it was fittingly called by its excavator.[20] Visitors in the third century BCE who used this street were travelling over an artery that had been Taxila's main thoroughfare since the time of its first settlement. We know this because